

COORDINATION OF BENEFITS · AUDIT WORKSHEET

Five COB Terms Decide How a Single Claim Coordinates. *The Flag Is Rarely Audited.*

Three audit passes. One COB clause. Where copay-program economics live.

This handout decodes the five COB terms: primary-secondary determination, member responsibility carve-out, Medicare-as-secondary handling, copay assistance crediting, and double-dipping prevention. Copay accumulator and maximizer programs depend entirely on accurate COB flagging at the claim level. Without auditing the flag, the program does not capture the manufacturer dollars correctly.

01 Pull the COB-flagged claims sample

Request a COB-flagged claims sample: claims where coordination applies because the member has secondary coverage, Medicare entitlement, or active manufacturer copay assistance.

If the PBM cannot produce a COB-flagged sample, that is the first finding.

02 Classify each COB scenario by type

For each COB-flagged claim, classify: primary-secondary, Medicare-as-secondary, manufacturer copay card, or member-billed-separately. Calculate share by type.

The manufacturer copay card category is rarely flagged correctly; if the flag is missing, the accumulator/maximizer program does not work.

03 Compare COB outcomes to the contract

Open your contract's COB clause. Note the rules: primary-secondary determination order, member responsibility carve-out, copay assistance crediting policy, double-dipping prevention.

Compare to actual claim outcomes. If the contract specifies maximizer-style and the workflow is accumulator-style, the workflow is doing different work than the contract.

04 The Pattern PBS Sees Most Often

Across hundreds of PBM contract reviews and audits annually at PBS: the manufacturer copay card crediting category is rarely flagged correctly. Copay accumulator and copay maximizer programs depend on accurate flagging at the claim level. If the flag is missing or wrong, the program does not capture the manufacturer dollars correctly.

05 Paste-Ready: Send to Your Broker or PBM

COB SAMPLE REQUEST · TO PBM

Subject: Coordination of benefits – flagged claims sample

Please provide a COB-flagged claims sample for the last quarter, including the following fields per claim:

- Member ID (de-identified or hashed)
- Drug name and NDC
- Date of fill
- Plan-paid amount (this plan)
- Member-paid amount
- Secondary coverage source: spouse plan / Medicare / copay card / other
- Secondary-paid amount
- COB rule applied (primary-secondary order, carve-out logic)
- Copay assistance flag: Y / N / partial
- Crediting outcome: counted toward deductible / OOP-max / bypassed

We expect to see all four COB scenario types represented.

Delivery requested within 14 business days.

06 This Quarter's Action Plan

STEP 1 · THIS WEEK

Request COB-flagged sample

If the PBM cannot produce, escalate. The flag exists in adjudication.

STEP 2 · WEEK 2

Classify the sample by COB type

Use the worksheet to calculate share by type. Manufacturer copay card mis-flagging is the most common audit finding.

STEP 3 · WEEK 3

Compare COB rules to actual outcomes

If contract says maximizer but workflow is accumulator, that is the gap.

STEP 4 · AT RENEWAL

Negotiate COB clause specificity

Vague COB language is where copay-program economics get lost.